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Page 1 — Cover

Japan on a Budget Trip Planner

See more of Japan for less — smart savings on transport, stays, food & activities.

A planning tool. All prices change — always check the latest before you book.

Page 2 — Where Your Money Goes (Read First)

Most travel spending in Japan falls into four buckets. Knowing the split helps you decide where to cut.

Category	Why it adds up	Biggest lever
Transport	Long-distance trips are pricey	Passes, slower routes, fewer hops
Accommodation	Nightly cost over many nights	Hostels, capsules, location, timing
Food	Three meals a day	Convenience stores, set meals, local spots
Activities	Entry fees and extras	Free sights, walking, free viewpoints

The budget mindset:

- Set a realistic daily target, not just a total.
- Spend where it matters to *you*; cut everywhere else.
- Slower and simpler is usually cheaper.
- Track as you go so a few big days don't blow the trip.

> ☒☒ Every figure changes by season and provider. Confirm current prices before relying on any number.

Page 3 — Transport: How to Save

Transport is often the single biggest cost, so it's the best place to plan carefully.

Tactics:

- ☒ Compare a rail pass vs. paying per trip for your actual route (see Page 4)
- ☒ Group long-distance trips to make a pass worthwhile, or skip it for single-city stays
- ☒ Use IC transit cards for local trains, subways, and buses
- ☒ Consider slower/cheaper train types or buses for some legs
- ☒ Look at overnight options that also save a night's lodging (confirm comfort/availability)
- ☒ Walk or cycle for short distances
- ☒ Base yourself centrally to cut daily transport

Decision rule: Add up your planned long-distance fares. If they're clearly above a pass price for the same coverage, a pass may pay off. If you're mostly in one city, per-ride with an IC card is often cheaper.

> Always check current pass terms, coverage, and eligibility — they change.

Page 4 — Transport Pass "Is It Worth It?" Worksheet

Planned long-distance trip	Estimated normal fare
1.	
2.	
3.	
4.	
Total normal fares	

- Pass price (current, confirmed): _____
- Pass covers all the trips above? ☒ Yes ☒ No / partial
- Total fares higher than pass price? ☒ Yes → pass likely worth it ☒ No → pay per trip

Verify pass coverage, validity period, and current price from the official source before deciding.

Page 5 — Budget Accommodation Guide

Plenty of clean, safe, low-cost options exist if you're flexible.

Option	Good for	Trade-off
Hostels / guesthouses	Solo & social travelers	Shared spaces
Capsule hotels	Short city stays	Compact, minimal
Budget business hotels	Privacy on a budget	Small rooms
Dorm beds	Lowest cost	Less privacy

Save more:

- ☒ Book earlier for better rates (especially busy seasons)
- ☒ Stay slightly outside the busiest central areas, near transit
- ☒ Choose places with free amenities (WiFi, simple breakfast, laundry)
- ☒ Travel in off-peak periods where possible
- ☒ Check cancellation terms before booking non-refundable deals

> ☒☒ Prices spike in peak seasons and around major events. Confirm current rates and policies.

Page 6 — Food: Eat Well for Less

You can eat well in Japan without spending much.

Cheap-eats checklist:

- ☒ Convenience stores — surprisingly good, cheap meals and snacks
- ☒ Set meals / lunch specials — often cheaper than dinner for the same food
- ☒ Standing or counter spots for quick, affordable bowls
- ☒ Supermarket deals, including end-of-day discounts
- ☒ Bakeries for cheap breakfasts
- ☒ Tap water is generally fine — carry a reusable bottle
- ☒ Food courts in shopping areas for variety on a budget

Money-savers:

- Lunch out, lighter dinner from a store.
- Share dishes if dining as a group.
- Skip pricey drinks; water or convenience-store drinks cost less.

> Confirm any dietary or allergy needs directly — translation help is useful here.

Page 7 — Free & Low-Cost Things to Do

Some of the best experiences cost little or nothing.

Free / low-cost checklist:

- ☒ Walk historic neighborhoods and shopping streets
- ☒ Visit parks and gardens (some free, some small fee — confirm)
- ☒ Many shrines and temples have free grounds (some charge for inner halls)
- ☒ Free city viewpoints / observation areas where available
- ☒ Riverside, harbor, and waterfront strolls
- ☒ Local markets for browsing and cheap snacks
- ☒ Seasonal nature spots (blossoms, autumn leaves)
- ☒ Free festivals and community events (check local listings)
- ☒ Window-shopping and people-watching in lively districts

My free-day plan:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

> Confirm hours and any fees before visiting — "free" areas sometimes have paid sections.

Page 8 — Daily Budget Tracker (print one per day)

Day ____ / Date _____ / Target daily budget: _____

Category	Planned	Actual
Transport		

Accommodation (per night)		
Food		
Activities / entry fees		
Other		
Total		

- Over / under target by: _____
- Adjustment for tomorrow: _____

Page 9 — Trip Budget Summary Worksheet

Category	Estimated total
Transport (incl. pass?)	
Accommodation (nights × rate)	
Food (days × daily food budget)	
Activities / fees	
Connectivity (eSIM/SIM/WiFi)	
Buffer / emergencies	
Grand total	

- Number of days: ____ → Average per day: _____
- Buffer added (recommended)? ☒ Yes ☒ No

Pack-to-save reminders:

- ☒ Reusable water bottle
- ☒ Reusable shopping bag (bags often cost extra)
- ☒ Power bank (avoid paid charging)
- ☒ Comfortable shoes (walking is free)
- ☒ Small trash bag

Page 10 — Final Budget Checklist & Notes

Before you go:

- ☒ Daily budget target set and realistic
- ☒ Transport pass decision made (worksheet done)
- ☒ Budget accommodation booked with terms checked
- ☒ Cheap-eats and free-spot lists ready
- ☒ Buffer for emergencies included
- ☒ All prices confirmed from latest official sources

Notes:

> Budgets are guides, not guarantees. Prices change constantly — track as you go, confirm the latest figures, and keep a small buffer for surprises.